Together, the protagonists of this book model the sort of critical footwork necessary to interrogate the entangled symbolic and physical life of barriers that continue to haunt the American experience. They draw close to repressive borders as a means to undermine them, compare them across cultures, observe their porous nature, and unpack the ways people seek to coexist despite their imposed separation. When we read the combined histories of such individuals within and outside the immediate contested zones of divided Berlin, their accounts elucidate features of the enduring military presence and diplomatic strategies of American power in this frontline city while also tracing the impact of such creative nonstate actors on the political knowledge of the Cold War period elsewhere. Through a litany of parallel Berlin-focused texts, works of art, and political acts, their works highlight practices and sites of division back home, set against a larger backdrop of postwar recovery and remediation in the German capital. While this book focuses on American narratives, it also channels and reflects on a large body of literature, social programs, monuments and memorials, and other platforms that reckon with the legacies of division and reunification in German culture. It is also an attempt to build on the scholarship of transnational scholars who have explored how U.S. power impacted, intertwined, and/or intentionally interfered with civic practices on both sides of divided Berlin.[8] By taking these scholarly texts together, animating them with archival materials and interviews with collaborators, and exploring related sites of memory in Berlin as well as in the United States, this book proposes to channel what Svetlana Boym deems “a dual archeology of memory and place.” My goal is to elucidate the city through artworks and publications that resonate with one another yet have never before been examined collectively in depth with an exploration of the city’s cultural memory as viewed from its own layered terrain.[9]

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The journeys of this book’s American Berliners can also be understood against a deeper historical context of American engagement with Germany after World War II, and eventually engagement directly with the Wall. Since 1945, in the wake of the allied defeat of Nazi Germany, the United States confirmed the fundamental importance of its relationship with post–World War II Germany. Following the halt of Hitler’s imperial and genocidal